February 1964 and Ayub to China in March 1965. By spring 1965, there was little chance India would come around to the US view of Pakistan as part of the solution to India's China problem.

The Indian government was both unwilling and unable to act on American suggestions to make Pakistan part of its China solution. Shastri had made clear as a minister and prime minister that the door to negotiations with Pakistan should remain open, including through an invitation to Ayub and a stopover visit with the Pakistani leader in October 1964. However, he had limited room to maneuver on Pakistan. For a new prime minister, sensitive to criticism that he was weak and indecisive, any settlement requiring concessions would only open him up to more such charges.[172]

Why did these disagreements on the right approach—toward spending, the Soviets, and Pakistan—not lead to a breakdown of the US-India relationship? For one, Soviet assistance to India was a stumbling block but not a deal breaker in US-India relations. Most in the Johnson administration were quite realistic about India's relations with the Soviet Union. As a policy planning paper suggested, the US goal when it came to Soviet engagement with India was not rollback but containment.[173]

Second, the US-Pakistan relationship was not sufficient to break Delhi and Washington up. On Kashmir, the Johnson administration was less activist than the Kennedy administration. Even the State Department, usually the US agency keenest to mediate, doubted the likelihood of a Kashmir settlement and acknowledged that US leverage was "demonstrably low"—not least because there was less Chinese military pressure on India.[174] Moreover, Indian officials knew that the US-Pakistan relationship was hardly at its peak thanks to Pakistan's dalliances with China and the Soviet Union. For all the talk of Johnson's admiration of Ayub, he found Pakistan and its leader exasperating. He later stated why: "When he's not in Peking, he's in Moscow and in both places he's denounced us."[175]

Finally, and shaping these two elements, concern about China kept India and the US tethered.

Mutual Disappointment (April–July 1965)